

York & the Minster - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Two Thousand Years in an Afternoon

Most cities give you one great age and ask you to imagine the rest. York gives you all of them at once, stacked, and lets you walk through the pile in a single afternoon. Stand almost anywhere in the old center and there is Roman stone beneath your feet, a Viking street name on the sign above your head, a medieval church at the corner, and a Georgian shopfront filling the gap between them. This is a small place, only about two hundred thousand people today, yet for the better part of two thousand years it was one of the most important cities in Britain, and the reasons kept changing.

It began as Roman Eboracum, a legionary fortress planted in the year seventy one where two rivers met, a spot the army liked because it could be supplied by boat and defended on two sides. It grew into a provincial capital, a place where emperors held court and, in one case, where an emperor was made. When Rome withdrew, the Angles took the ruins and renamed them; then a Danish army arrived and made York the capital of a Viking kingdom, a story we will save for tomorrow. Out of all of that came the medieval city you are standing in, a place of guilds and pilgrims and one of the largest cathedrals north of the Alps.

And then, crucially, the story slowed. York stopped being essential, and that is exactly why so much of it survived. What you are about to walk through, the walls, the crooked butchers' street, the enormous Minster, is not a reconstruction. It is the actual thing, left standing because the rest of the world moved on. Listen on for how the layers got here, and how to read them.

The City Where an Emperor Was Made

Try to picture Roman York not as a ruin but as a working city, because that is what it was for more than three centuries. A fortress the size of a small town sat on the high ground, home to roughly five thousand soldiers of a single legion, with stone barracks, bath houses, granaries and a headquarters building whose foundations still lie directly beneath the Minster. Across the river a proper civilian city grew up, with merchants, temples, a marketplace and the villas of the wealthy, important enough that Rome eventually named it the capital of the northern half of Roman Britain and granted it the rank of *colonia*, the highest status a Roman city could hold.

The name, by the way, may be the oldest thing here. Eboracum seems to come from an ancient British word for a place of yew trees, older than Rome itself, and it has quietly survived every conquest since, worn down over the centuries from Eboracum to Eoforwic to Jorvik to the single blunt syllable we use now, York.

This far-northern city kept pulling the whole empire toward it. Emperors came in person to run their wars against the tribes of what is now Scotland, and two of them died here. The second death is the one that mattered. In the year three hundred and six, the emperor Constantius died in York, and his soldiers, standing in this city, immediately proclaimed his son emperor on the spot. That son was Constantine, later called the Great, and within a few years he had legalized Christianity across the Roman world and founded a new capital, Constantinople, that would outlast Rome itself by a thousand years. It is not an

exaggeration to say that one of the hinge moments of Western history happened in a garrison town in northern England. There is a statue of him now, lounging with his broken sword outside the Minster, a few steps from where the acclamation is thought to have taken place. Give him a nod. Very few provincial cities can say they manufactured an emperor who changed the world.

Reading the City in Layers

When the Roman legions finally left Britain in the early fifth century, York did not vanish; it changed hands. The Angles, a Germanic people, moved into the old Roman shell and renamed it Eoforwic, and in doing so they gave it a second golden age, this one Christian and scholarly. In the year six hundred and twenty seven, the Northumbrian king Edwin was baptized here on Easter Day, in a hastily built wooden church that stood on the very spot the great stone Minster occupies now. Every stone of that cathedral, in a sense, grows out of that single wet morning.

The Anglo-Saxon city became famous for its learning. Its cathedral school held what was probably the finest library in England, and it produced a scholar named Alcuin, who in the year seven hundred and eighty two was recruited by no less a figure than Charlemagne to run the schools of his empire. A boy educated in York ended up shaping the education of half of Europe. Then, in the eight hundred and sixties, a great Danish army swept in and took the city, and York entered its Viking chapter as the capital of a northern kingdom they called Jorvik. But that is tomorrow's story, and it deserves its own day, so we will leave the Vikings knocking at the gate for now.

Here is the useful part for a walker. All of these ages are still legible if you know where to look. The walls you can climb largely follow the line the Romans first laid down. Any street whose name ends in gate, and there are many, from Stonegate to Coppergate to Petergate, carries a Viking word, gata, meaning street, so the very act of asking directions puts a little Old Norse in your mouth. The word bar, confusingly, means a gateway in the wall, medieval this time. And beneath the Minster itself, in the Undercroft, you can walk down through the actual strata, Roman wall, then Norman, then Gothic, one age resting on the bones of the last. York does not tuck its history away in a museum case. It leaves it lying around in the street, and hands you the trick of reading it.

Saved by Being Left Behind

Here is the paradox at the heart of York. The thing that makes it so wonderful to visit, its astonishing completeness, is a direct result of its decline. For centuries York was the great city of the North, second only to London. But when the industrial revolution came in the seventeen and eighteen hundreds, the money and the smoke and the sheer explosive growth went elsewhere, to Leeds and Bradford and Manchester, cities built on coal and cloth and iron. York, with no coalfield of its own, was largely passed over. It stayed a market and cathedral town while its neighbors doubled and tripled in size. That was, at the time, a disappointment. In hindsight it was the luckiest thing that ever happened to it.

Because a booming city knocks itself down and rebuilds. A quiet one keeps what it has. The old fabric of York, the walls, the churches, the tangled medieval lanes, simply stayed put because there was no fortune to be made in clearing it away. It very nearly went otherwise. In the year eighteen hundred the city corporation actually applied to Parliament for permission to demolish the walls, calling them crumbling and inconvenient, exactly as London and most other English cities were tearing theirs down. What saved York's walls was an early conservation campaign, led by influential citizens including the painter William Etty, who fought the demolition and won. Because of that fight, York today has more surviving city wall than anywhere else in England, a nearly complete circuit you can walk for free.

So what should you notice today? Notice that the completeness is real. That medieval street is not a film set; those walls are not a replica; the Minster is the actual medieval cathedral, not a Victorian imitation.

Notice, too, the compromises that keep a living city alive, like the great railway arches punched through the ancient walls in the eighteen thirties so the trains could reach the center. York is not a museum where nothing may change. It is a place that learned, earlier than most, that the past is worth keeping, and then went on living inside it. That is the rarest thing here, and it is all around you.

From Eboracum to York: A Capital in Layers

York's claim to be England's second city historically rests on an extraordinary run: Roman legionary fortress and provincial capital, seat of two imperial courts, Anglo-Saxon royal and ecclesiastical center, Viking capital, and the medieval North's metropolis. Eboracum was founded in 71 AD by the Ninth Legion; the emperor Septimius Severus ruled the entire Roman Empire from here for three years while campaigning in Scotland, and died here in 211 — as did Constantius Chlorus in 306, whereupon the army acclaimed his son Constantine as emperor in York, an event with reasonable claim to be the most consequential thing that ever happened in northern England, given where Constantine took Christianity. Roman masonry still surfaces everywhere: the Multangular Tower in the Museum Gardens stands to height, and a Roman column re-erected opposite the Minster came from the fortress headquarters — which lies directly beneath the Minster itself; the Undercroft museum takes you down through the strata. The city walls, though medieval in their present form, largely ride on the Roman rampart line — at three point four kilometers the most complete circuit in England, walkable and free. The gates, or “bars,” did double duty as toll points, defenses and billboards of state terror: Micklegate Bar displayed the heads of traitors, including Richard, Duke of York in 1460 — crowned mockingly with paper — and rebels' heads remained a feature into the 1740s. Shakespeare has Queen Margaret order it: “Off with his head, and set it on York gates; so York may overlook the town of York.”

The Ninth Legion and the Working Fortress

Strip away the Vikings and the medieval walls and you reach York's foundation: a Roman legionary fortress, laid out on the high ground between two rivers in seventy-one, after the future emperor Petillius Cerialis pushed north. This was not a town but a military machine, home to a full legion, roughly five thousand professional soldiers, with the ordered geometry the Romans imposed everywhere, a rectangular circuit of walls, a grid of streets, headquarters, granaries, barracks, and a bathhouse whose remains you can peer at beneath a pub on Saint Sampson's Square, aptly named the Roman Bath. The corner of that fortress still stands ten courses high as the Multangular Tower in the Museum Gardens, its small Roman stones capped by larger medieval ones, a cross-section of the city in a single wall. The legion that built all this was the Ninth, Legio Nona Hispana, and it has become one of the great enigmas of Roman history. The Ninth garrisoned York, rebuilt its gates in stone, and then simply disappears from the record. The last firm evidence of the legion anywhere is an inscribed slab commemorating their reconstruction of a fortress gateway around one hundred and eight, now displayed in the Yorkshire Museum. After that, silence. By the middle of the second century the Ninth is gone from the army lists, and no later trace of it survives anywhere in the empire. The romantic explanation, immortalised in Rosemary Sutcliff's novel *The Eagle of the Ninth*, is that the legion marched into the mists of Caledonia and was annihilated by the northern tribes. Most modern historians are sceptical, and suspect a more mundane end, a transfer out of Britain, perhaps to the Rhine, and destruction years later in some lost war in the East, possibly the great Jewish revolt under Bar Kokhba or a campaign against Parthia. Either way, an entire legion vanished from history, which is a genuinely rare thing, and it happened to the very unit that gave York its first walls. Their replacement was the Sixth Legion, Legio Sexta Victrix, which arrived around one hundred and twenty-two in the emperor Hadrian's baggage train and made Eboracum its home for the best part of three centuries. So the fortress outlived the men who built it, and the mystery of the Ninth remains York's oldest unsolved case, hiding under the pavements you are standing on.

Clifford's Tower and the Sabbath of 1190

The grassy mound crowned by a stone quatrefoil is Clifford's Tower, the keep of York Castle, and it is the setting of the darkest night in the city's history. The motte was thrown up for William the Conqueror around ten sixty-eight, one of two castles he planted to hold a city that kept rebelling; for its first century the keep on top was built of timber. In March eleven ninety, England was seized by crusading fever after the coronation of Richard the First, and a wave of anti-Jewish violence swept the country. York had a prosperous Jewish community, technically the personal property and responsibility of the king, and therefore both protected and resented. As the mob gathered, the community took refuge in the royal keep on this mound. The siege that followed was stoked by local gentry who owed the moneylenders substantial debts, chief among them Richard Malebisse, whose name conveniently translated as evil beast, a pun contemporaries did not miss. Trapped in the wooden tower on the night of the sixteenth of March, the eve of the great Sabbath before Passover, many of the besieged chose to take their own lives and those of their families rather than submit to forced baptism, setting the tower ablaze as they did. Those who surrendered the next morning on a promise of mercy were murdered anyway. Around one hundred and fifty people died, and the community was effectively extinguished. The killers then went to the Minster and burned the records of the debts they owed, which for some had been the point all along. The stone tower you see replaced the burned timber one: it was built for Henry the Third in the mid-thirteenth century in that distinctive four-lobed plan, and it takes the name Clifford probably from Roger de Clifford, hanged in chains from its walls in thirteen twenty-two. Its own end came in sixteen eighty-four, when an explosion, whether accident or arson, gutted the interior and left the roofless shell that survives. A memorial at the foot of the mound now marks the massacre, and the site has become a place of reflection as much as sightseeing. Climb it for the view over the rooftops to the Minster, by all means, but climb it knowing what happened here, because the prettiest cities often keep their hardest stories in their most photographed spots, and this is York's.

The Bar Walls and the Four Great Gates

If you do one free thing in York, walk the walls. The circuit runs about three and a half kilometres, the most complete medieval town walls in England, and it rides for much of its length on the earth rampart the Romans threw up around their fortress, so you are quite literally walking the outline of Eboracum. The Victorians nearly lost it for us. In the eighteen thirties the Corporation, finding the walls an inconvenient antique, began pulling sections down, and it took a public outcry, led by men who would now be called conservationists, to stop the demolition and save the circuit you can walk today. Their instinct that a city might be worth more intact than convenient is why the tourists come.

The great set pieces are the bars, the fortified gatehouses that controlled every road into the city and doubled as toll booths, prisons and billboards of royal power. There are four principal ones, and each has a character. Bootham Bar, on the north west, stands roughly where the Roman gate stood, guarding the old road to the wild moors, and until the fourteenth century it carried a door knocker that strangers had to use to beg the Lord Mayor's permission to enter. Monk Bar is the tallest and most defensible, a four storey tower with murder holes for dropping unpleasant things on attackers, and it is the only bar in York that still keeps a working portcullis, the iron grille that could crash down to seal the arch. It was last lowered in nineteen fifty three, and for years the rooms above housed a small museum devoted to Richard the Third, whose story is bound up with this city more than any other king's. Walmgate Bar, on the east, is the rare survivor that still has its barbican, the walled forecourt that funnelled attackers into a killing ground before they even reached the gate, the only English city gate to keep that feature intact.

And then Micklegate Bar, the grandest, the ceremonial southern entrance by which monarchs traditionally arrived, touching the sword of state held out to them by the Lord Mayor. It was also, for centuries, the place where the heads of traitors were displayed on spikes as a warning, a practice that ran from the medieval wars into the seventeen forties. Walk up onto the walls at Micklegate and look back at the city,

and you are standing where a severed head once looked out over the town that shared its name. Bring the children up here. It is a battlement, it is free, and the view of the Minster floating above the rooftops is the one they will remember.

The Minster: Glass, Fire and the Long Build

York Minster is the largest medieval Gothic cathedral north of the Alps, built over roughly two hundred fifty years from 1220 as successive archbishops competed with Canterbury in stone. Its unmatched treasure is glass: the Minster holds around half of all the medieval stained glass surviving in England, an accident of the Civil War — the city's 1644 surrender was negotiated by Thomas Fairfax, a Yorkshireman who explicitly protected the churches from iconoclasm. The Great East Window, finished by 1408 by John Thornton of Coventry under a three-year contract with an on-time bonus, is the largest single expanse of medieval glazing in the world — a tennis court of glass narrating Creation to Apocalypse in over three hundred panels; its decade-long modern conservation, completed in 2018, was among the largest projects of its kind ever undertaken. The Five Sisters window in the north transept is older still — thirteenth-century grisaille, five lancets of silvery-grey geometry — and since 1925 has been the country's only memorial dedicated to women of the British Empire who died in the First World War. The building's afterlife has been eventful: an arsonist burned the choir in 1829; the central tower's foundations were found in the 1960s to be failing — the rescue excavation created the Undercroft, where you descend past Roman barracks and Norman foundations; and the 1984 south transept fire, days after a controversial bishop's consecration there, gave the restoration one charming touch — six of the new roof bosses were designed by children who won a television competition. Look up for a spacecraft among the medieval-style carvings.

The Chapter House, the Clock, and the Treasures

The glass gets the headlines, but the Minster rewards the visitor who explores its edges. Step into the Chapter House, the octagonal room off the north transept where the cathedral's governing canons once met. Completed in the twelve eighties, it performs a quiet feat of engineering: its wide vaulted ceiling has no central column. A stone vault of that span would have demanded a supporting pillar in the middle; instead the medieval carpenters built the roof in timber, cantilevered and balanced so that it holds itself, leaving the floor gloriously open. Around the walls runs some of the finest naturalistic thirteenth-century carving in England, canopies crowded with heads, foliage and grotesques, and a Latin inscription that boasts, with justification, that as the rose is the flower of flowers, so this is the house of houses. In the north transept, pause at the astronomical clock. It looks medieval but was installed in nineteen fifty-five, and it is a war memorial: its dials show the heavens as they would appear to an airman flying over York, commemorating roughly eighteen thousand aircrew from the bases of Yorkshire, Durham and Northumberland who died in the Second World War, their names recorded in a Book of Remembrance beneath it, a page turned each day. Then descend to the Undercroft treasury for the Horn of Ulf, an oliphant carved from a single elephant's tusk in Salerno, in southern Italy, in the early eleventh century. It is not merely decorative: the Anglo-Scandinavian magnate Ulf is said to have presented it to the church as the physical token conveying his estates, a drinking horn serving as a title deed in an age when a symbol placed in the hand outweighed any document. Finally, back in the nave, look high on the wall for the wooden dragon's head projecting into the space, painted and fierce, its original purpose long lost but most plausibly a medieval crane, a chain once running through the hole in its skull to raise and lower the heavy cover of the font below. None of these is the thing visitors come to see, which is precisely why they repay the detour: the self-supporting roof, the clock that maps a pilot's sky, the ivory horn that bought land, and the dragon that was really a machine. The Minster keeps its cleverest ideas in its corners.

Saint William, the Doomstone, and the Long Campaign

The Gothic Minster you walk through, begun in twelve twenty, is the latest great church on this spot, raised over a Norman cathedral that Archbishop Thomas of Bayeux began after the Conquest, which in

turn sat on the headquarters building of the Roman fortress. That layering is literal, and you can read it in the Undercroft. Down there, look for the Doomstone, a Norman carving from the twelfth century depicting the mouth of Hell as a great cauldron, demons shovelling the damned into it while toads and a money-bag-clutching miser illustrate the wages of greed. It is Romanesque terror at full volume, the medieval imagination's answer to a warning sign, and it survived precisely because it was buried and forgotten until the modern excavations uncovered it. The Minster also has its own saint, largely forgotten today, whose story is pure twelfth-century politics. William Fitzherbert was made Archbishop of York, then deposed amid accusations of bribery and unsuitability as reforming monks lobbied against him, then restored years later after his rivals faltered. He returned to York in triumph in eleven fifty-four, and within weeks was dead, taken violently ill after celebrating Mass, with poison in the chalice widely suspected and never proven. His enemies were accused; nothing was ever established. Miracles were soon reported at his tomb, he was canonised as Saint William of York in twelve twenty-six, and his shrine drew pilgrims and their offerings, the medieval equivalent of tourist revenue, helping to fund the very rebuilding you are admiring. A magnificent window in the choir, the Saint William Window, narrates his life and posthumous miracles across dozens of panels. Behind all of it lay a long rivalry with Canterbury over which archbishop held primacy in England, a competition fought partly in stone: York's canons wanted a cathedral that would not be outshone. That ambition is why the building took two and a half centuries to complete, why its glass and its towers are on the scale they are, and why a provincial northern city ended up with the largest Gothic cathedral in northern Europe. Faith, politics, a suspicious death and civic pride, all set in magnesian limestone, and most of it invisible unless you know to look for the buried mouth of Hell and the saint whose name the building has quietly kept.

The Tower That Nearly Fell, and the Fort Beneath

Stand under the great central tower of the Minster, the vast lantern where the arms of the cross meet, and consider that in the nineteen sixties it was quietly falling down. When Bernard Feilden was appointed Surveyor of the Fabric and had the foundations properly examined between nineteen sixty five and sixty seven, the news was alarming. The tower, sixteen thousand tons of stone, was sinking and cracking, its medieval footings inadequate for the weight the builders had piled on them over the centuries, and engineers concluded that without intervention it could collapse. The BBC filmed a report memorably titled to the effect that York Minster was falling down, and a national appeal raised around two million pounds, an enormous sum then. Between nineteen sixty seven and nineteen seventy two, engineers from the firm of Ove Arup burrowed beneath the cathedral and underpinned it, threading stainless steel rods and pouring reinforced concrete collars around the ancient foundations, an invisible modern skeleton inserted to hold the medieval building up. The tower you are standing under is alive today because of that rescue.

And then came the dividend that no fundraiser could have promised. To reach the failing foundations the engineers had to dig, and as they dug they broke through into York's deepest past. Beneath the south transept they found the north corner of the Roman Principia, the headquarters building of the legionary fortress, its great walls and column bases still standing where the Sixth Legion left them. The cathedral, it turned out, was built squarely on top of the command centre of Roman York, one seat of power laid directly over another across sixteen centuries. Rather than fill the excavation back in, they turned it into the Undercroft museum, and you can now walk down and stand among Roman masonry, Norman foundations and that modern concrete, reading the whole history of the site in the strata of a single stairwell. Your ticket includes it. Do not skip it.

When you come back up and step outside, the story continues in the open air. Opposite the south transept stands a genuine Roman column, some six metres of it, which was found broken and buried under the tower during those very excavations in nineteen sixty nine. It once held up the roof of that same Principia, and the Dean gave it to the city, which re-erected it in nineteen seventy one to mark nineteen hundred

years since the fortress was founded. A few steps away sits the bronze figure of Constantine, unveiled in nineteen ninety eight, lounging with his broken sword, marking the spot where the army made him emperor. Column, statue and cathedral within a stone's throw of one another, each a different layer of the same eighteen hundred year old story. And if you glance up at the west end of the Minster as you go, look for the semaphore saints, twelve modern headless figures added in two thousand and four, each holding its arms in the flag signalling code so that together they spell out, letter by letter, the words Christ is here. Twelve hundred years of belief, still finding new ways to say the same thing on the same wall.

The Great East Window: How to Read the End of the World

Everyone stands in front of the Great East Window and admires it as a wall of colour. Learn to read it, and it becomes something stranger and greater: a medieval attempt to picture the entire history of everything, from the first day of Creation to the last day of the world, in a single frame of glass the size of a tennis court. The chapter of York commissioned it in fourteen oh five and handed the job to John Thornton, a master glazier from Coventry, on a three year contract. He delivered in fourteen oh eight, and the surviving accounts record his fee as fifty six pounds, a serious sum for the age but a rounding error against what the window has cost to keep alive since.

Read it in three bands. The very top rows, up in the tracery you can barely make out from the floor, take their subject from the Book of Genesis: God creating the heavens and the earth, and the early sacred history of the world. The great central grid, the part your eye actually lands on, is given over to the Book of Revelation, the apocalypse of Saint John, and it is thought to be the largest depiction of the apocalypse anywhere in the world. This is where the medieval imagination lets itself off the leash. Look for the seven angels with their trumpets, the beast rising from the sea, the four horsemen, the dragon with seven heads, the woman clothed with the sun, the pouring out of the seven bowls of wrath, and finally the New Jerusalem descending, the world made new. The bottom rows return to earth with rows of bishops and kings, the human authorities who commissioned and blessed the whole scheme. At the very apex sits God enthroned, holding a book that reads, in Latin, I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end, which is the window's entire argument in six words.

Then consider what it took to save it. By the twenty first century the glass was failing, the lead corroding, six hundred years of grime and earlier bad repairs obscuring Thornton's colour. Between two thousand eight and two thousand eighteen the York Glaziers Trust took the window apart, all three hundred and eleven panels, and conserved them one by one, the largest single conservation of medieval stained glass ever attempted in this country, often called the biggest medieval jigsaw in England. It cost around eleven and a half million pounds, part of a wider eighteen million pound campaign called York Minster Revealed. The panels went back behind a second, external skin of clear protective glazing, so the medieval glass no longer meets the weather at all. So when you look east, you are looking at fifty six pounds of Thornton's labour, preserved by eleven and a half million pounds of ours, and at a six hundred year old vision of how the world ends, still glowing exactly as it was meant to.

The Rose Window and the Screen of Kings

Turn to the south transept, the arm of the cathedral that burned in nineteen eighty four, and look up at the Rose Window, the great wheel of glass set high in the gable. It is easy to walk past as pretty geometry, but it is one of the most political windows in England, because it is a peace treaty rendered in glass. It was made in the early fifteen hundreds to mark the marriage of Henry the Seventh, the first Tudor king, to Elizabeth of York, and the design carries the red rose of Lancaster and the white rose of York interlaced together. The two houses had spent thirty years slaughtering each other in the wars we now call the Wars of the Roses. This window is the propaganda of the peace that followed, the two roses fused, the dynasty reconciled, the message being that the bloodletting was over and the Tudors were the union of both sides.

That it survives at all is the second half of the story. When the south transept roof caught fire in the small hours of that July night in nineteen eighty four, the Rose Window was subjected to heat of around four hundred and fifty degrees. It did not shatter and fall, but the glass crazed, cracking in something like forty thousand separate places while somehow holding its shape, a spider's web of fractures across the whole wheel. The York Glaziers Trust bonded adhesive into every one of those forty thousand cracks and had it back in place within four years, and it is being nursed again in our own decade as those emergency repairs begin to age. A window that celebrates the end of one war has now survived a fire that could easily have ended it.

Before you leave the crossing, look at the great stone screen that separates the nave from the choir, because it belongs to the same royal theme. This is the Kings' Screen, carved in the fifteenth century, and ranged along it are fifteen almost life sized statues of the kings of England, in sequence, from William the Conqueror at one end to Henry the Sixth at the other. Count them and you will find the arrangement is lopsided, seven kings on one side of the central doorway and eight on the other, and there is a reason. The screen was begun under Henry the Fifth, and when he died young the figure of his infant son Henry the Sixth was added beside him, tipping the balance. So the screen is not just decoration, it is a dynasty carved in stone, a line of succession you can walk along, the very kingship that the Wars of the Roses would soon tear apart. Roses and kings, faith and power, all gathered at this one crossing under the tower.

The Shambles and the Snickelways: Medieval Streetscape as Survival

The Shambles — from “fleshammels,” the shelf-benches of butchers’ stalls — is routinely called Europe’s best-preserved medieval street, and its picturesqueness is entirely functional in origin. This was York’s dedicated butchery from at least the fourteenth century (Domesday Book already records butchers’ stalls here in 1086); the jettied upper floors that nearly touch overhead were built out to shade the meat displayed on the sill-boards below, and the raised pavements flanking a central channel managed the offal and blood. Some twenty-five butchers still traded here in the late nineteenth century; the last closed within living memory, and the hooks and sill-boards survive on several frontages. The street’s modern fame has a second layer: its resemblance to Diagon Alley — inspiration is claimed rather than confirmed by the filmmakers — has filled it with wizardry shops, an irony the tourist board has embraced without complaint. One sobering address: number 35 was the home of Margaret Clitherow, the butcher’s wife executed in 1586 for harboring Catholic priests — pressed to death under a door loaded with stones after refusing trial to protect her children from testifying — later canonized; a shrine on the street (probably not her actual house, scholarship suggests) marks her. Around the Shambles spreads the network of snickelways — the term coined only in 1983 by author Mark Jones, blending snicket, ginnel and alleyway — some fifty medieval shortcuts threading between streets. Lund’s Court, formerly Mad Alice Lane, and the passage grandly named Whip-Ma-Whop-Ma-Gate, York’s shortest street with its longest name, are the connoisseur’s picks.

Related listening: Guy Fawkes, the man behind the Gunpowder Plot, was born and raised in York. Listen back — “The Palace of Westminster: Fire, Gothic and the Longest Hall” (Westminster Walk, Day 6).

Guy Fawkes and the Catholic Underground

York’s prettiest streets have a Catholic underground running beneath them, and its most infamous son was born a few steps from the Minster. Guy Fawkes came into the world in fifteen seventy in a house on Stonegate, and was baptised days later in Saint Michael le Belfrey, the church that stands cheek by jowl with the cathedral’s west front, its register still recording the entry. He was schooled in the city, at what is now Saint Peter’s School, alongside boys from families who would later turn recusant, that is, Catholics who refused to attend the state Protestant church and paid ruinous fines, or worse, for the refusal. Fawkes was born into a conventional Protestant household but converted to Catholicism as a young man, went abroad to fight for Catholic Spain in the Low Countries, where he acquired the military and gunpowder experience that made him useful, and adopted the name Guido. In sixteen hundred and five he became the hands-on man of the Gunpowder Plot, a conspiracy to blow up the House of Lords at the state opening of Parliament and, with it, King James the First, decapitating the Protestant establishment in a single blast. Thirty-six barrels of gunpowder were smuggled into a cellar beneath the chamber. An anonymous tip-off led to a search in the small hours of the fifth of November, and Fawkes was caught red-handed guarding the powder, giving a false name, ready to set it off. He was tortured, tried, and executed. The nation has burned his effigy every fifth of November since, which makes him the rare historical figure commemorated by a bonfire rather than a statue. His old school, with a nice sense of loyalty to a former pupil, is famously said to decline to burn a guy to this day. But the deeper York story is the one the souvenir shops leave out. This was a city where faith could be lethal, where families hid priests in concealed chambers, smuggled Mass vessels, and paid informers to look the other way, and Fawkes was simply its most spectacular product. The fudge counters and the wizard shops now sit on top of a century in which what you believed might cost you your house, your freedom, or your neck.

The Treasurer's House and the Ghosts of a Haunted City

York markets itself, with some justification, as one of the most haunted cities in Europe, and if you want a single ghost story that has survived hard scrutiny, it is the one told in the Treasurer's House, close by the Minster. In nineteen fifty-three an eighteen-year-old apprentice named Harry Martindale was fitting pipework in the cellar when he heard a repeated note like a trumpet and then watched a Roman soldier emerge from the solid wall, followed by a carthorse and a straggling column of perhaps a dozen legionaries, dishevelled, weary, carrying round shields. The detail that has kept the story alive is this: he saw them only from the knees upward, as though they trod a surface below the modern floor. Martindale, badly shaken, recounted the tale consistently for the rest of his life and never took a penny for it. What lifts it above the ordinary is what the archaeology later showed. The Treasurer's House stands directly over the line of a Roman road, and the buried road surface lies at exactly the depth of the soldiers' hidden feet. More striking still, the round shields and scruffy appearance he described, initially dismissed as wrong for legionaries, actually fit the irregular troops garrisoning York in the later Roman period, details an untrained young plumber was unlikely to have invented. Sceptics reach for the well-documented tricks of memory and suggestion; believers point to a witness who never embellished and never profited. Either way it is a better story than most, because it is anchored in real stratigraphy. It also stands for something true about York as a whole: this is a city built in layers, where the past is quite literally underfoot, and the ghost walks that set out nightly from the Minster gates trade on a genuine sense that the dead are close to the surface here. You will pass the Golden Fleece, reputedly the city's most haunted pub, and a dozen guides in top hats promising highwaymen and grey ladies. Take the theatre for what it is. But the Treasurer's House tale endures because it fits the ground, and because a man told it the same way for fifty years and asked for nothing in return. In a city this old, the boundary between history and haunting is thinner than the tourist board even needs it to be.

The White Rose: York and the Wars of the Roses

The county wears a white rose to this day, on cricket caps and county flags and the badges of Yorkshire regiments, and that flower is a direct inheritance from the bloodiest dynastic quarrel in English history. The Wars of the Roses, fought on and off between about fourteen fifty five and fourteen eighty five, were a struggle for the crown between two branches of the royal family, the House of Lancaster, whose badge was a red rose, and the House of York, whose badge was the white. The name itself is a later, romantic invention, tidied up by Sir Walter Scott, but the roses were real enough as symbols, and this city gave its name to one whole side of the war. When you walked in past Micklegate Bar you were reminded of the price: the head of Richard, Duke of York, the very man who launched the Yorkist claim to the throne, was set on a spike over that gate in fourteen sixty after he was killed at the battle of Wakefield, and his enemies mockingly crowned the severed head with a paper crown, jeering at the king he never became.

But it is his youngest son who binds this city to the wars most deeply, and his name is Richard the Third. Before he was king he was Duke of Gloucester, and Edward the Fourth made him effectively the ruler of the north, governing from the great Yorkshire castles and building an unusually warm relationship with York itself. The city knew him, traded with him, sent men to his campaigns, and received his favours in return. And here the record does something historians rarely get: it lets us hear a city's private grief. When Richard was killed at the battle of Bosworth in fourteen eighty five, defeated by Henry Tudor, the news reached York within a day, and on the twenty third of August the city council had its clerk write in the official minute book that King Richard, late mercifully reigning upon us, was piteously slain and murdered, to the great heaviness of this city.

Pause on that. This is the same Richard the Third whom Shakespeare would turn into a hunchbacked child killing monster a century later, the villain of the London stage. Yet the men of York, who actually knew him, wrote of great heaviness, of grief, and they wrote it while the new Tudor king was very much alive and very much watching. It was a genuinely dangerous thing to commit to the record. Henry the Seventh never trusted the north for exactly this reason, and his suspicion shaped the way the region was governed for the next century. So the white rose you see everywhere in Yorkshire is not just a pretty county emblem. It is the badge of the losing side, the flower of a defeated dynasty, worn with a certain northern stubbornness ever since, and this is the one city in England that publicly mourned the king the rest of the country was taught to hate.

Henry the Eighth and the Breaking of the North

Walk into the Museum Gardens and you come upon the ruins of Saint Mary's Abbey, elegant broken arches standing in the grass, and they are the wound that Henry the Eighth left on this city. Before the fifteen thirties, Saint Mary's was one of the richest Benedictine monasteries in the north of England, a walled precinct of monks, libraries, guest halls and vast estates, right beside the city. Then came Henry's break with Rome, his quarrel with the Pope over his marriage, and the Dissolution of the Monasteries, the systematic closing and stripping of every religious house in the kingdom and the seizing of their wealth for the crown. Saint Mary's was surrendered in fifteen thirty nine, its community turned out, its lead and stone carted away, and what you see now is what the centuries left of one of the great abbeys of the north.

The north did not take this quietly. In the autumn of fifteen thirty six, Yorkshire rose in the largest rebellion any Tudor ever faced, the Pilgrimage of Grace. Under a charismatic lawyer named Robert Aske, an army of perhaps thirty thousand pilgrims, marching under banners of the five wounds of Christ, demanded that Henry halt the dissolution and turn out his hated minister Thomas Cromwell. Aske's forces, some nine thousand strong, occupied York itself, restored expelled monks to their houses, and for a

moment held the whole of the north. It was not a peasant riot but a broad coalition, gentry and commons together, and it genuinely frightened the government. Henry could not beat it in the field, so he lied his way out of it, offering pardons and a promise of a parliament at York, waiting for the rebels to disperse, and then, when a fresh disturbance gave him the excuse, striking hard. Robert Aske was tried for treason and, in July fifteen thirty seven, hanged in chains from Clifford's Tower, the same mound you can see across the city, left to die slowly and rot in public as a warning.

Henry's answer to a rebellious north was to govern it harder. He revived and strengthened a body called the Council of the North, a regional government that ruled the northern counties in the king's name, and he housed it here in York, in the King's Manor, the former abbot's lodging of the very abbey he had just destroyed. You can still visit the building, now part of the university. And in fifteen forty one Henry himself came north for the only time in his life, entering York in September with his fifth queen, Katherine Howard, while the city, desperate to be forgiven for the Pilgrimage of Grace, met him with abject ceremony and expensive gifts. Within months that same young queen would be arrested for adultery and beheaded. So the ruins in the Museum Gardens are not just a photogenic backdrop for a picnic. They are the physical evidence of the moment the old religious north was broken to the will of a Tudor king, and the place where a great rebellion was crushed and then, quite deliberately, ruled from the wreckage of what it had died to defend.

Dick Turpin and the Gallows on the Knavesmire

For most of its history York was not only the capital of the north but its courtroom and its gallows, the place where the assizes met and where the region's condemned were brought to die. The great judicial executions happened out on the Knavesmire, the low common ground on the edge of the city, at a spot known as the York Tyburn, named after the more famous gallows in London. Today the Knavesmire is the racecourse, and thousands cheer horses across ground where crowds once gathered to watch hangings, which is a very York sort of layering. And the most famous man ever turned off there was Dick Turpin.

The Turpin most people carry in their heads is almost entirely fiction. The dashing highwayman on his faithful mare Black Bess, galloping two hundred miles through the night from London to York in a single heroic ride, is a Victorian invention, dreamed up by the novelist William Harrison Ainsworth in a romance called *Rookwood* in eighteen thirty four, nearly a century after Turpin was dead. There was no such ride, and Black Bess never existed. The real Richard Turpin was a butcher's son from Essex who fell in with a vicious gang of deer poachers and house breakers, graduated to highway robbery, and eventually shot a man dead. He fled north under a false name, John Palmer, and set himself up in Yorkshire as a horse dealer, funding the front by stealing the very horses he sold.

What undid him was petty and almost comic. Arrested for causing a disturbance and suspected of horse theft, he wrote a letter from York prison to his brother in law back in Essex, asking for help. The brother in law refused to pay the postage, so the letter sat in the post office, where it was recognised by a man who had once taught Turpin to write and knew his hand. The handwriting hanged him. Tried at York for horse stealing, a capital crime then, he was sentenced to death, and he seems to have decided to die well, buying himself a new frock coat and hiring five mourners to follow his cart. He was hanged at the Knavesmire on the seventh of April seventeen thirty nine and buried in the churchyard of Saint George, near Fishergate, where a worn stone still marks the supposed grave. Even that was not the end of the indignity: body snatchers dug him up for the anatomists within days, and a mob had to chase them down and rebury him. So when you hear the romance of the gallant highwayman, remember the truth York knew, a horse thief betrayed by his own handwriting, who paid strangers to weep for him, and whose legend was written by a novelist a hundred years too late to be contradicted.